read books from other countries is not enough. If socialism is to be built up in India it will have to grow out of Indian conditions, and the closest study of these conditions is essential. We want experts in the job who study and prepare detailed plans. Unfortunately our experts are mostly in Government service or in the semi-official universities, and they dare not go far in this direction.

An intellectual background is not enough to bring socialism. Other forces are necessary. But I do feel that without that background we can never have a grip of the subject or create a powerful movement. At the present moment the agrarian problem is far the most important in India, and it is likely to remain so. But industry is of little less importance, and it grows. What is our objective: a peasant State or an industrial one? Of course we are bound to remain predominantly agricultural, but one can and, I think, must push on industry.

Our captains of industry are quite amazingly backward in their ideas; they are not even up-to-date capitalists. The masses are so poor that they do not look upon them as potential consumers, and fight bitterly against any proposal to increase wages or lower hours of work. Recently hours of work have been reduced from ten to nine in the cotton mills. This has led the Ahmedabad mill-owners to reduce the wages of labour, even piece-work labour. Thus the reduction of hours of work has meant a lower income and a yet lower standard for the poor worker. Rationalisation, however, proceeds apace, increasing the pressure on the worker and his fatigue, without any proportionate increase in wages. The whole outlook of the industry is an early nineteenth-century one. They make stupendous profits when they have the chance and the worker continues as before; if there is a slump the owners complain that they cannot carry on without reducing wages. Not only have they the help of the State, but also usually the sympathy of our middle-class politicians. And yet the lot of the cotton worker in Ahmedabad is better than that of a similar worker in Bombay and elsewhere. The cotton workers, on the whole, are better off than the jute workers of Bengal and the miners. The workers of the small disorganised industries are lowest in the industrial scale. To compare the magnificent palaces of the jute millionaires and the cotton lords, with their ostentatious display of pomp and luxury, with the wretched hovels where their semi-naked workers live, should be an education of the most impressive kind. But we take these contrasts for granted and pass them by, unaffected and unimpressed.